

Striving towards Democracy

The United States Democracy has a governmental system called Democracy, which grants “power to the people.” At least, that’s what my middle school history teacher told me.

But a simple look into the history of the US shows that this is a half truth propagated by (as Freire would say) bank-clerk instructors and bank-clerk politicians who throw the word around carelessly: in magnanimous speeches on Fourth of July celebrations, in declarations of war and conquering, in Pleads to Congress to reshape the law, and even in the mundane everyday address. Using the language of democracy casually indicates that the US is a democracy, but most political scientists worth their salt would classify the US as a Republic.

So then, what gives? Why call the US a Democracy when it’s a Republic? I do wonder how this misleading language impacts us, and if I was truly happy living in a Republic or if I wanted to see true reform.

When I shared this thought with a with a friend from Lebanon last summer. He giggled, which made me a little indignant as I thought we were discussing something serious, and told me that if I lived in Lebanon, I would have been shot like 6 times already in the course of our conversation. His remarks sobered my perspective- America definitely isn’t as oppressive and caricature-esque as I made it out to be, and it definitely has more democratic elements than I wanted to concede, even if it is just a Republic. The root of my (admittedly immature) anger stemmed from identifying the word “democracy” as a noun meant to define our governmental system, instead of an adjective that describes it.

Democracy makes more sense as a descriptor that exists on a spectrum. America is technically defined as a Republic, but it is not inaccurate to describe it as a democratic Republic, as opposed to Russia, which is also a Republic, but arguably should be described as less democratic.

Moreover, there is too much subjectivity tainting democracy to allow it to exist as a true subject. Again, some scholars may make arguments that some countries had a democracy (for example, in the case of Athens), but other scholars will inevitably refute these claims. On the other hand, there are subjects like apples and bananas, where nobody will ever refute that it is an apple or a banana. Concepts like Democracy are likely too amorphous and full of subjective ideals to pinpoint as a noun the real world. Instead, democracy is sort of a North star illuminating the sky amid murky, foggy waters. This beacon serves as a guide for where to go and which shores to turn to next, but is notably distinct from the sailor's destination. There is no star that our human ships can ever anchor at; Democracy is not a state that can be achieved.

To further this idea that Democracy cannot exist as a subject, consider Athenian Democracy. The Ahoy Polloi podcast episode describes Athenian democracy under Pericles in a sort of idyllic light: Anybody in Periclean Athens who wanted to be a part of the government could just show up, get paid to do so, and have true influence. I am told that many call this system the closest to true democracy, and I am tempted to agree, until I remember that Athens also had a lot of slavery and no rights for women. They had a very successful democracy for a tiny fraction of the population (naval officers), and their system would likely not work without this exclusivity, as there would be nobody else to do the other jobs. To me it makes more sense to say that Athens has some very democratic aspects built into its governmental system, but it feels morally abhorrent to call a society where some humans didn't even own the rights to their own bodies, let alone have the power to influence the state they lived in, a capital D

“Democracy.” Real life is more nuanced, and if one of the most widely agreed upon examples of the “truest” democracy is a severely flawed democracy with many undemocratic elements, it is unlikely that a true Democratic system can ever exist.

Examining the many states we call democratic has shown me that to some extent, Democracy is solely a utopian idea: thought-provoking and helpful for informing our reality, but not actually realistic. But why does it matter? Who cares if we call America a republic, a democracy, a mess, an island, etc. Yet the use of language informs how we see the world. If we perceive America as the pinnacle of democracy, with institutions carefully crafted to represent democracy, we as citizens are accepting the status quo. If the end goal has been achieved, if we are okay with the fact that other countries have it worse, we give ourselves permission to rest. The momentum of change is halted, and there is no reason to strive for anything better. In this way, I think my anger at the evil politicians is justified. Even if politicians use the fanfare of the Democratic language with the best intentions, it can shroud the faults of our de facto political system. We cannot extricate a pure Democracy from the messy mixture of oligarchical, meritocratic, democratic, tyrannical, and republican institutional forces comprising our system, but taking the time to carefully choose our language and clearly define our systems is the first step in getting closer.

Works Cited

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